

Magic Quadrant for Multichannel Marketing Hubs

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AI assistants and agents are commonplace in multichannel marketing hubs in 2026. What separates platforms now is control: advanced decision-making algorithms that optimize journey, offer and consent state at the moment of action, governing what both humans and AI can do in service of engagement.

Market Definition/Description

Gartner defines multichannel marketing hubs (MMH) as platforms that enable marketing teams to design, orchestrate and optimize multistep customer journeys across multiple channels. This is done by unifying customer attributes, identity and interaction history, then applying decision logic and analytics in order to activate messaging through native execution or integrated channel services with governed measurement, consent and operational controls.

MMHs help marketing and marketing operations teams plan, build, launch and improve multichannel campaigns and event-driven journeys at scale. They solve the need to coordinate sequences of customer interactions that span channels, time and contexts, while governing eligibility and incremental impact, enforcing consent and preference controls as well as consistently measuring outcomes across those channels.

Tangible outputs include:

- Measurable journey performance through touchpoint-level and journey-level reporting that supports auditing, testing, versioning and iteration (e.g., identifying drop-off points, comparing variants and tuning rules).

- Governed multichannel activation that applies consistent suppression, frequency and eligibility controls.
- Measurable journey performance through touchpoint-level analysis and journey-level roll-up reporting that supports iteration.

MMHs typically integrate upstream data sources for profile and event context, and integrate downstream channel execution services when native execution is not available, but the MMH remains the control plane for journey state, sequencing and operational governance. MMHs are distinct from adjacent categories, such as customer data platforms (CDPs), email service providers and personalization engines. This is because the MMH serves as the system of record for multistep journey design, durable journey state, cross-channel activation, governance and journey-level measurement, while those adjacent systems primarily provide data and single-channel execution, or offer decision making.

Mandatory Features

The mandatory features for this market include:

- Multichannel journey and campaign design that support triggers, branching, waits and exit conditions with persistent journey state.
- Multichannel activation executed from the same application, either natively or through integrated channel services (e.g., email, SMS, mobile push, in-app messaging, web or app notifications, direct mail, etc.) that are governed from the MMH.
- Cross-channel suppression and frequency or fatigue controls that can block or throttle activation across the channels in scope.
- Audience selection and activation-ready audiences (segments that can be used directly in journeys or campaigns for eligibility and activation).
- Consent or preference handling that affects activation eligibility, either natively or through integrated policy services with enforceable outcomes.
- Measurement and reporting for message-level (touchpoint-level) performance, plus journey-level roll-ups.
- Testing and release controls for journeys and/or campaigns, including A/B/n testing, or holdout capability and versioning, with publish history or rollback.

- Operational governance, including roles and permissions plus auditability of changes to journeys, campaigns and related governance settings.

Optional Features

The optional features for this market include:

- Advanced channel expansion beyond owned channels, including paid and earned activation integrations.
- Two-way and conversational engagement patterns, including inbound message handling and escalation or handoff.
- Prescriptive optimization features, including recommendations or automated tuning of journey or campaign orchestration decisions (e.g., cadence, channel selection, branching thresholds).
- AI-assisted content or creative variant generation with guardrails and approval support.
- Collaboration and work management features connected to campaign and journey production workflows.
- Event and context trigger ingestion that extends responsiveness, including external signals and location context.
- Commerce and service integrations that enrich journey context and support continuity across functions.
- Utilization and consumption reporting with guardrails for spend, quotas or rate limits, including optional forecasting of channel volumes or consumption impact prior to deployment.

Magic Quadrant

Figure 1. Magic Quadrant for Multichannel Marketing Hubs



Magic Quadrant for Multichannel Marketing Hubs



Gartner

Vendor Strengths and Cautions

Adobe

Adobe is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its main MMH solution comprises several Adobe CX Enterprise (formerly Adobe Experience Cloud) products: Adobe Journey Optimizer, Adobe Real-Time CDP and Adobe Customer Journey Analytics. The vendor's operations are global, and its clients tend to be global and large enterprises in consumer packaged goods, healthcare, financial services, retail, travel and hospitality, and technology. Adobe's roadmap includes plans to expand customer profiles to capture and store qualitative customer context

and mobile/chat conversations, extracting customer intent to enable AI agents to make better decisions across all products in the Adobe Experience Platform (AEP).

Strengths

- **Multichannel reach and activation:** Adobe supports orchestrating, personalizing and frequency-capping campaigns and journeys across a comprehensive set of channels. These include email, SMS/MMS/RCS, push, WhatsApp, Google Ads, Meta Ads and paid social platforms. It enforces consent and preference management policies across both owned and paid channels.
- **AI agents:** Adobe CX Enterprise Coworker is its agentic workflow layer that manages a set of specialized agents across CX Enterprise products and external agent systems (e.g., MCP server, A2A integrations). The agents are goal-oriented and support multistep campaign creation from a business brief, test variations in customer journeys and diagnose root causes of campaign performance issues.
- **Federated customer profile management:** Adobe's Federated Audience Composition enables marketers to compose and activate audiences directly from enterprise data warehouses (e.g., Microsoft Azure Synapse, Google BigQuery, Databricks, Snowflake) without ingesting data into AEP. This reduces operational risk and supports compliance with data residency and governance requirements.

Cautions

- **Product interdependencies:** Adobe's solution architecture often requires multiple products to unlock full functionality. Marketers licensing Journey Optimizer as a stand-alone solution may find limitations. For example, native social and ads connectors (e.g., Meta Ads) are commercially restricted and require a separate Real-Time CDP license. Although Adobe is developing a modular "social connectors bundle" to address this gap, current stand-alone Journey Optimizer customers cannot natively activate audiences to walled-garden ad platforms.
- **Optimization maturity requirements:** Journey Optimizer's native prescriptive optimization model requires data scientists to manually interpret journey analytics and adjust campaign flows, as advanced automation features are limited without additional products. For capabilities such as automated traffic routing in one-click, organizations would need to license Adobe Target. Those seeking highly customized optimization models or cross-channel programs would benefit from specialized expertise.

- **System coherence:** Adobe's modular architecture can result in fragmented user experiences and increased implementation overhead. Although AEP promises a unified experience, co-deployed applications function differently depending on the product tier licensed (e.g., activating an audience in a separate destination such as Adobe Target). Adobe does not provide contractual SLAs for cross-system latency or data handoffs, relying instead on noncontractual performance guardrails and internal service-level targets.

Airship

Airship is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its Airship Experience Platform (AXP) delivers mobile-led customer engagement anchored in the native app, mobile web and marketing channels, such as email, SMS, wallet passes and live activities. Airship operates in North America, EMEA and APAC, with clients ranging from midsize to large B2C enterprises concentrated in travel, media and retail. Recent investments center on deterministic in-session orchestration through the Scenes AI Agent, as well as an agentic layer built on Google Cloud, where Airship's analytics already reside. Its roadmap prioritizes agent orchestration, real-time performance monitoring and data warehouse interoperability.

Strengths

- **Mobile channel execution:** Airship operates at the leading edge of mobile engagement, serving buyers seeking specialized capabilities. Its depth in push, wallet, live-activity and in-app capabilities is well-established across key travel, media and retail accounts. This gives brands whose highest-value customer moments happen inside the app a higher level of specialized focus than other platforms in this evaluation.
- **In-app journey execution:** Mobile environments run at speeds and with characteristics that generalist platforms do not accommodate. Airship's deterministic Scenes logic and embedded content give app and web teams precise control over in-session experiences without waiting on app release cycles.
- **One-stop agent orchestration:** Airship's agents operate alongside its engagement analytics, so in-app behavior can branch or suppress a journey in the same session rather than on an overnight sync. Marketers set the guardrails under which those agents operate, and each change and recommendation carries an audit entry and rationale for analysis.

Cautions

- **Multichannel marketing scope:** Airship’s platform shows a pronounced mobile-app channel skew and its broader multichannel depth is under-attested in public customer case studies. AXP’s support for offline CRM systems, ledger databases and legacy data warehouses is limited, reducing suitability for buyers in regulated industries needing complex segmentation or audit capabilities.
- **Profile and context dependencies:** Airship’s architecture is heavily optimized for in-session personalization rather than enterprisewide cross-channel journeys. Airship natively delegates key operations — specifically data quality assurance, data lineage tracking and probabilistic identity stitching — to third-party tools. Buyers seeking offline customer data or complex audience building or reporting should assess Airship’s fit within their existing martech investments.
- **AI and agent scope:** Buyers pursuing agentic orchestration across multiple business units and teams may find Airship’s AI strategy — centralizing agents and analytics within Google Cloud — too restrictive. Unlike platforms that offer a “bring your own model” approach, Airship’s agents operate on a single, managed provider. This restricts data science and compliance teams from substituting models or arbitrating between different providers to optimize cost, latency or compliance.

Bloomreach

Bloomreach is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Bloomreach Marketing, powered by the Loomi platform, is a core MMH with modular components focused on personalized, data-driven multichannel marketing and B2C commerce experiences. Its capabilities span customer data management, campaign orchestration and real-time personalization. Bloomreach operates in EMEA, North America and APAC. Its clients tend to be large enterprises and midsize organizations in retail, gaming, media, entertainment, financial services and consumer packaged goods (CPG). Its product roadmap prioritizes headless interoperability via the Loomi Connect MCP, native warehouse activation via Databricks CustomerLake, adaptive multiagent workforces and portfolio optimization.

Strengths

- **AI-driven personalization and decision making:** Bloomreach’s in-memory framework holds profiles, event history, segmentation and catalog states in one place, enabling highly tailored customer experiences across channels. Models such as contextual personalization utilize reinforcement learning bandits to autonomously learn variant, timing and channel choices per individual in real time.

- **System coherence:** Under its unified architecture, all modules share Bloomreach's Loomi platform, meaning they utilize a single, shared data layer, one identity graph, one real-time infrastructure and one AI engine. By operating this way, on a single substrate, buyers can prevent consent drift, while any new execution channel added inherits the platform's central frequency, suppressions and compliance controls by default.
- **Commerce integrations:** The platform supports seamless data flow and campaign orchestration for omnichannel retail and CPG clients. It handles catalogs, nested objects and relational data, making complex product attributes (such as real-time stock and pricing) instantly accessible.

Cautions

- **Data and partner requirements:** While time to value is relatively fast, the platform's schema-less architecture requires disciplined data engineering upfront to ensure data quality and hygiene. Onboarding for enterprise deployments might require certified regional service partners.
- **SKU proliferation:** Bloomreach's core offering has predictable pricing based on core marketing licenses and monthly unique visitors, but costs can become more complex as organizations add advanced capabilities through separate licensed modules. Buyers should scope their intended use cases up front to prevent contract complexity and unexpected licensing sprawl.
- **Prescriptive maturity:** Automated root cause analysis, needed when a KPI moves unexpectedly, and portfolio-level continuous auto-optimization remain forward-looking roadmap items for Bloomreach. Buyers should ensure internal analytics or data science teams are included in evaluating predictive and prescriptive modeling to understand how this could impact total cost of ownership.

Braze

Braze is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its customer engagement platform and BrazeAI Decisioning Studio focus on real-time, cross-channel customer engagement, emphasizing composability and zero-copy data platform integration. Braze's operations are geographically diversified, with a strong presence in North America, EMEA and APAC. Clients tend to be large enterprises and midsize companies, particularly in retail, financial services, and media and entertainment industries. Its product roadmap focuses on transitioning from single-agent

automations to adaptive, multiagent coordination workflows and conversational AI messaging. It also includes perpetual campaign execution via its campaign composer, Canvas, to deliver highly governed, individualized customer journeys.

Strengths

- **Composability and interoperability:** Braze Cloud Data Ingestion, part of the Braze Data Platform, connects to warehouse and data lakehouse platforms (e.g., Snowflake, Databricks, Google BigQuery) to ingest user attributes, events, purchases, catalogs and privacy deletion requests without requiring custom middleware or ETL pipelines. This benefits clients seeking robust interoperability and flexible architecture.
- **Real-time multichannel engagement:** The platform's real-time engagement and personalized cross-channel execution enable personalization within milliseconds and adaptive customer journeys by unifying profiles, event streams, campaign metadata and templates within a single execution layer. This especially benefits clients in retail and media, where timely interactions drive business outcomes.
- **AI-driven orchestration and governance:** Braze integrated its June 2025 acquisition, OfferFit, as BrazeAI Decisioning Studio. This tool leverages reinforcement learning (specifically, contextual bandits) to autonomously experiment and select the optimal channel, message, creative, incentive and timing at a one-on-one level.

Cautions

- **Complexity and time to market:** Braze's platform may require significant technical resources for initial integration and ongoing management, which will be a challenge for organizations with limited IT support. Buyers should assess their internal capabilities and consider engaging implementation partners if needed.
- **Pricing structure:** Braze's pricing structure can be complex, particularly for organizations with fluctuating messaging volumes or evolving cross-channel requirements — although its roadmap may increase transparency, as it includes billing, forecasting and alerts. Buyers should understand and evaluate their ability to govern spend and ensure it aligns with value generated to justify the investment when comparing solution pricing.
- **Advanced analytics and reporting:** Some advanced analytics and reporting features are not supported, such as lifetime value (LTV) or customer lifetime value (CLV) modeling, audience discovery and look-alike modeling, and marketing mix modeling. These limitations may affect complex organizations or buyers in highly regulated industries.

Buyers should request customer references to ensure the platform meets their specific data and compliance needs.

CleverTap

CleverTap is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. It focuses on product-led engagement for mobile-first brands, supporting unified customer profiles and a broad ecosystem of integration, as well as adaptive customer journeys. It natively executes mobile push, in-app messaging, WhatsApp, iOS Live Activities, email and web personalization, while orchestrating carrier (e.g., SMS) and other channels (e.g., paid media) through a flexible partner-led delivery framework. CleverTap operates mostly in APAC, with additional presence in EMEA and North America. Clients tend to be midsize to large enterprises, particularly in fintech, e-commerce and retail, and gaming and entertainment. Its product roadmap prioritizes native MCP server support (to enable headless workflows) and governed autonomous agents.

Strengths

- **Composability and headless workflows:** CleverTap offers a highly extensible, API-first architecture and bidirectional data warehouse integrations. This provides flexibility for clients that have complex technology stacks and/or want to access the platform through different modalities.
- **Product and mobile multichannel focus:** The platform is natively architected on TesseractDB, a purpose-built database that handles over 50 billion user actions daily. Its focus on high-scale, subsecond event-triggered messaging makes it well-suited for high-velocity consumer organizations, in-app and email communication, and adaptive customer journeys.
- **Behavioral segmentation:** CleverTap's behavioral segmentation and predictive suite, including prebuilt RFM templates, past behavior segments and user affinity models, is natively unified and marketer-centric. This includes CleverAI, which supports decision making such as propensity, and offers selection designed for marketers to activate and run, facilitating campaign setup and scaling.

Cautions

- **Operational visibility:** The platform's consumption management tooling is not yet fully native. Self-serve consumption dashboards, forecast run-rate overage alerts and cost-per-outcome reporting are roadmap items, but buyers must currently rely on manual tracking

via customer success teams to detect usage spikes and prevent unexpected overage charges.

- **Advanced orchestration:** While mobile push, web layers, WhatsApp and in-app triggers are supported natively, email and SMS delivery require partner-led integrations, which can be configured without coding. Buyers should request detailed information to validate the platform's ability to support complex, cross-channel and two-way messaging marketing strategies.
- **Geographic presence:** CleverTap has less penetration in North America and EMEA compared with global competitors. Buyers with multinational operations should assess its regional support capabilities and local market expertise.

Insider One

Insider One is a Challenger in this Magic Quadrant. Its agentic customer engagement platform delivers multichannel messaging, AI-driven personalization and conversational commerce capabilities. Insider One operates primarily in APAC, with an expanding presence in North America and EMEA. Clients are predominantly midsize to large enterprises in consumer packaged goods, financial services, retail, transportation and telecommunications. The product roadmap includes an app that leverages Insider One's data with direct access to ChatGPT. It also includes the ability for customers using cloud data warehouses (e.g., BigQuery, Databricks, Snowflake) to build and activate audiences directly within Insider One. Additionally, an agent-guided error-resolution experience will provide step-by-step instructions to help customers resolve data issues independently, with configurable email alerts.

Strengths

- **Audience management:** Insider One enables marketers to analyze, segment and activate audiences in real time directly within the platform, supporting complex segmentation criteria without restrictions on audience size, filters or event ingestion. This approach streamlines campaign targeting and reduces reliance on external business intelligence tools.
- **Conversational chatbots:** The platform offers a native chatbot, which embeds shopping and support agents within multichannel customer journeys. Conversational signals are synchronized in real time with the unified customer database, enabling personalized interactions to drive revenue across web, SMS, WhatsApp and Instagram channels.

- **Automated journey optimization:** Insider One provides A/B testing with automated winner selection and dynamic path allocation, allowing marketers to configure, monitor and optimize customer journeys without manual oversight. The platform evaluates performance and automatically reroutes customers to the most effective paths multiple times daily.

Cautions

- **Probabilistic identity resolution:** Insider One's CDP explicitly does not support probabilistic identity resolution (IDR) in its platform and does not maintain formal partnerships with probabilistic IDR providers. Its focus on deterministic matching limits its suitability for buyers seeking to orchestrate unknown-to-known buyer journeys in a single platform.
- **Pricing strategy:** Standard contracts include automatic annual price escalations, potentially increasing total cost of ownership over multiyear deployments faster than business value. While usage analytics are available, a centralized billing metrics system is still in development, limiting oversight of consumption patterns.
- **CRM suite overlap:** Insider One's expansion into customer service and commerce agents introduces redundancy for some MMH buyers. Brands with established service applications will face some overlap between capabilities and workflows in Insider One and their existing CRM investments.

Iterable

Iterable is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its AI-powered platform orchestrates personalized cross-channel campaigns using real-time behavioral signals and customer data. Delivered as a unified, single-tenancy solution, Iterable offers additional licensable features such as Smart Ingest and the premium AI Suite. Iterable operates in North America, EMEA and ANZ, serving midsize to large B2C enterprises in retail, media, travel and consumer goods. Recent enhancements include Nova Agent upgrades (e.g., segmentation and campaign metric querying) and Stored Messages for audit-ready records. Future plans will enable seamless zero-copy data integration and agent-led conversational messaging across SMS and RCS channels within customer journeys.

Strengths

- **B2C focus:** Iterable's dedicated B2C focus enables it to tailor its platform, support model and product innovation to the needs of large consumer-facing brands, particularly in

industries such as retail, travel and media. Its Nova Agent helps marketers accelerate campaign cycle times through campaign development, data activation, greater agility and stronger campaign performance.

- **Flexible data activation:** Iterable's open, API-first architecture enables real-time activation and personalization directly from enterprise data sources, while its visual no-code tools make sophisticated audience engagement accessible without technical expertise. Upcoming enhancements, including Smart Ingest 2.0, aim to further strengthen scalability and data flexibility for large enterprise deployments.
- **AI agents:** Iterable's upgraded Nova Agent accelerates campaign development with content generation, journey creation and natural-language analytics, while Stored Messages provides audit-ready records of delivered communications, including message content, personalization and journey context. Together, these enhancements help marketers execute campaigns more efficiently while improving visibility and accountability across customer communications.

Cautions

- **Geographic reach and support:** Iterable's customer base and support resources are concentrated in North America, with presence in other regions trailing Leaders. Multinational organizations must carefully evaluate regional coverage, local language requirements and time zone alignment to ensure adequate service levels outside of North America.
- **Owned-channel execution scope:** Iterable best serves buyers seeking to engage their customers on owned channels. Beyond retargeting customers via walled gardens, paid social and retail media are not supported; RCS and conversational, two-way messaging are roadmap items; and attribution is limited, by design, to last touch and explicit campaign attribution.
- **Nova assistive limits:** Generative campaign execution via Nova Agent remains assistive and requires human approval for certain agent-driven actions, with greater autonomy and advanced features still on the roadmap. Organizations seeking fully autonomous AI workflows should assess whether Nova's current human-in-the-loop model aligns with their operational requirements and long-term AI strategy.

Klaviyo is a Challenger in this Magic Quadrant. Its B2C CRM comprises email, mobile and social messaging and pairs with its Klaviyo Data Platform (KDP) and Marketing Analytics product. Klaviyo operates in North America, Latin America and EMEA. It serves midsize to large B2C organizations concentrated in retail, e-commerce and adjacent consumer verticals. Recent releases center on agentic AI, including Composer for natural-language campaigns, a customer-facing service and sales agent, and an MCP server for external tool integration. Klaviyo's roadmap prioritizes conversational marketing and service agents, introduces deeper enterprise data controls via its Organization feature, adds probabilistic identity resolution and expands location-based physical retail tracking.

Strengths

- **Retail and e-commerce fit:** Klaviyo delivers a commerce-centered marketing platform that combines a data platform with common e-commerce platform connectors. Users can integrate transaction histories, on-site browsing behaviors, campaign response history and product reviews into individual profiles, then activate those profiles across email, SMS, push and web channels using built-in predictive analytics.
- **Optional data management:** Klaviyo bridges data storage and multichannel journey orchestration through its data platform, KDP. It supports bidirectional data warehouse synchronization, allowing teams to activate segments and custom objects from the warehouse within downstream journey paths while keeping data centralized and governed.
- **AI agents:** Klaviyo's Composer agent builds target audiences, coordinates channel selections and generates creative copy from plain-language prompts. It requires explicit human approval before launch. Conversely, its Customer Agent autonomously resolves two-way service and sales conversations directly inside active threads under brand-configured guardrails.

Cautions

- **Presence in regulated industries:** Klaviyo has few public record case studies or named clients in banking, insurance, healthcare or similar compliance-heavy industries. Buyers in these industries should ask for named customers operating in similar regulatory environments and assess Klaviyo's platform for consent, audit and residency controls.
- **Bundled profiles and context:** Clients must budget for KDP and the additional channel-specific products from the outset. Buyers with mature data or CDP deployments can still

use Klaviyo's channel-execution tools independently of KDP. However, the execution layer alone cannot deliver full multichannel marketing or journey orchestration without it.

- **AI post-training and data use:** Klaviyo's standard terms of service permit it to refine its AI assistant by analyzing marketer interactions, which could give an advantage to competitors also using Klaviyo. The vendor contractually guarantees that first-party shopper data, uploaded policies and brand catalogs are never used to train models. Buyers concerned over AI post-training should assess the consent, opt-out and data control terms in their contract for both consumer and internal marketer interactions.

MoEngage

MoEngage is a Niche Player in this Magic Quadrant. Its agentic customer engagement platform enables personalized, multichannel campaign orchestration across email, mobile, web, messaging and paid media. MoEngage's operations started in APAC, but it has a growing presence in North America and EMEA. It serves mostly B2C midmarket and enterprise organizations in financial services, media and retail. Recent enhancements include AI assistant capabilities for creative generation and prompt-based audience targeting. The vendor's roadmap focuses on agents and insight AI to help marketers onboard, define and plan campaigns, identify anomalies and make recommendations to drive optimization.

Strengths

- **Intuitive UI:** MoEngage's intuitive platform allows users to create, execute and optimize campaigns across multiple channels through a visual journey canvas, drag-and-drop features and AI-assisted capabilities that streamline audience targeting, channel orchestration and message creation.
- **AI-assisted productivity:** MoEngage combines zero-copy access to warehouse segmentation with AI-assisted campaign creation. It enables marketers to activate audiences directly from cloud data warehouses and supports secure personalization through PII tokenization. Its Merlin AI Studio offers AI-assisted segment creation, journey-flow design and content generation, streamlining campaign execution to reduce operational effort.
- **Customer success/technical support:** MoEngage provides customer support and implementation services as part of its standard licensing, including onboarding assistance, email deliverability support and access to customer success resources. Support from a

dedicated customer success manager, ongoing training programs and regular business reviews help with platform adoption and campaign execution.

Cautions

- **Geographic focus:** While MoEngage is expanding in North America and EMEA, its local delivery is still maturing. Because the vendor performs most implementations in-house, Western buyers may face bottlenecks during onboarding, which averages 70 to 85 days. Buyers should evaluate whether the vendor, or its emerging network of regional system integration partners, possess the resources to handle integration and onboarding needs.
- **Operational review overhead:** Although MoEngage has introduced its Merlin AI suite to support AI-assisted campaign creation, its creative and generative copilots are structurally restricted to an assisted, draft-only model that requires manual human-in-the-loop review, approval and publishing before campaign activation. This may limit value for organizations seeking advanced end-to-end autonomous campaign activation.
- **Marketing and customer support coherence:** While MoEngage provides conversational messaging capabilities across multiple channels, it relies on partner solutions for live-agent support and customer service workflows. Buyers requiring a unified platform for both marketing and customer support should evaluate the extent of partner dependencies and integration requirements.

Optimove

Optimove is a Visionary in this Magic Quadrant. Its unified, four-layer platform encompasses customer profiles, AI-driven decision making, channel execution and orchestration, and measurement. Optimove operates mostly in EMEA, with additional clients in North America. It serves midsize and enterprise organizations primarily in financial services, online gaming and retail. Its roadmap includes marketing financial operations, featuring a dashboard for cross-channel agent and data tracking, budget visibility and spend/utilization forecasting. Optimove also plans to automate the transformation of marketing briefs into complete campaigns or journeys, including audience selection, offer management, journey flows and dynamic content template creation.

Strengths

- **No-code data manipulation:** Users can ingest and transform data, create calculated fields and construct complex audiences through a no-code interface, now enhanced with

conversational capabilities via external agents such as Claude or ChatGPT. The platform supports both batch and real-time data ingestion without incremental licensing fees or data volume restrictions.

- **Context-aware marketing:** Optimove's Content Intelligence agent automatically tags every outbound campaign message with attributes such as offer type, tone and image style. These tags are mapped to campaign performance over time, enabling predictive insights into individual customers' content preferences. All campaign data is also accessible to client data warehouses through Data Share.
- **External AI support and customization:** Optimove's MCP server exposes the platform's full functional surface (e.g., profiles, segments, templates, campaigns, reports) to external AI agents with strict read/write parity and role-based access controls. This enables the external agents to build audiences or trigger campaigns securely. For advanced requirements, clients can collaborate with Optimove's AI engineers to create tailored enterprise solutions.

Cautions

- **Data access and governance:** Optimove provides a SQL console only for zero-copy audience building against external data warehouse connections (e.g., Snowflake). Broader in-platform data transformation limits users to no-code UI tools. This aligns with its MCP server, which exposes a governed semantic layer rather than raw SQL to external AI. An AI-assisted SQL console remains on the roadmap.
- **Chatbot conversation management:** While Optimove natively processes inbound messaging replies and performs natural-language intent classification, it lacks full end-to-end conversation management. Key bottom-of-funnel features — such as live agent hand-off and in-thread transactional check-out — are available only through partner integrations.
- **Long-term pricing ambiguity:** Although foundational LLM-based features are currently available at no additional cost, this model might be temporary. Optimove is evaluating a consumption-based or "bring-your-own-tokens" model to offset LLM hosting costs. This shift may introduce budget volatility for marketing teams heavily reliant on Optimove's LLM-based workflows.

Salesforce

Salesforce is a Leader in this Magic Quadrant. Its Marketing Cloud offering supports multistep customer journeys within an enterprise-scale platform. It centers on Marketing Cloud Next and is supplemented by Data 360, Marketing Cloud Personalization and Marketing Cloud Intelligence. Salesforce is based in North America but operates globally, serving small, medium and large banking, insurance, healthcare, media and retail clients. Recent investments focus on Marketing Cloud Next and AI agents, such as its Marketing Cloud Campaign Agent. The vendor's product roadmap prioritizes agentic decision making across journeys and personalized, dynamic content orchestration, supported by its June 2026 acquisition of Contentful.

Strengths

- **Enterprise proof and presence:** Salesforce unites traditionally disaggregated sales, service and marketing experiences. Marketing Cloud extends existing CRM applications and workflows, enabling marketers to coordinate campaigns based on real-time business signals. The platform's support for cross-functional orchestration allows brands to orchestrate across digital and human touchpoints.
- **Unified profiles for Marketing Cloud Next:** Marketing Cloud Next natively connects existing workspaces to Data 360's unified customer profiles. This allows marketers to run current campaigns and journeys on the profile, and behavioral data already stored in the CDP. The shared architecture also enables brands to segregate customer profiles and execute campaigns at the brand level while maintaining a single enterprise view.
- **Agentic decision-making architecture:** Marketing Cloud places campaign and journey decision-making agents on the same platform as the data and execution layers. Human approval requirements and audit logging provide essential governance. Marketing Cloud can dynamically pause or modify active marketing journeys in real time based on immediate business events occurring across the Sales or Service Clouds, such as suppressing messages when customers log support tickets.

Cautions

- **MCE+ commercial transition:** Next-generation agentic features are priced by usage, with charges for longtime Marketing Cloud Engagement+ (MCE+) customers beginning after an initial allotment. Unlocking these capabilities requires a new MCE+ license. Customers moving from MCE to MCE+ should request a range of pricing scenarios, as this new product's volume-tiered variable fees depart from a like-for-like license transition.

- **Consumption-based pricing:** Data 360 and Marketing Cloud users incur operational costs with every profile reconciled and AI action. While Digital Wallet monitors credit consumption and triggers threshold alerts, neither it nor the platform natively freezes execution or throttles ingestion at budget limits, although this capability is on the roadmap. To prevent automatic overage billing, buyers must build custom Salesforce Flows triggered by Digital Wallet alerts to manually pause services.
- **Agentic decisioning and autonomy:** Salesforce's planned Marketing Cloud Campaign Agent differs from traditional next-best-action tools, which arbitrate available journeys, channels and offers for a customer. Rather than selecting from those options, it dynamically builds campaigns, promotions and content for an interaction, using a continuous test-and-learn approach to suppress future iterations of underperforming decisions. Because the agent operates distinctly from past decision intelligence engines, enterprise buyers should assess its fit for replacing legacy personalization tools.

SAP

SAP is a Challenger in this Magic Quadrant. Its SAP Engagement Cloud targets organizations seeking AI-driven personalized engagement via integration with SAP Business Suite and SAP Business AI Platform. SAP operates mostly in EMEA, North America and APAC, serving enterprise and upper midmarket clients in retail, e-commerce, consumer products, sports and entertainment, utilities, and travel and hospitality. Recent investments include evolving Joule into a hierarchical framework with four generally available Joule Assistants (Content, Campaign, Marketing Strategy, and Lifecycle Orchestration). SAP's current roadmap includes new agents for brand governance, localization and journey optimization, launched via JouleWork , a central workspace where marketers configure custom agents with parameter-based guardrails.

Strengths

- **Industry vertical accelerators:** SAP accelerates enterprise speed to market by aligning its library of prebuilt, industry-specific campaign blueprints with a zero-copy data foundation. Outside IT development cycles, marketers can leverage SAP's Universal Schema Builder to read external cloud data platforms directly. The integration lets marketers use industry-specific blueprints — templates for customer life cycle management, cross-selling and loyalty triggers — to pull live data products at query time.
- **AI-assisted orchestration:** Four generally available Joule Assistants embedded in SAP Engagement Cloud reduce production bottlenecks in content creation, campaign design,

strategic recommendations, and lifecycle orchestration. The ability to use natural-language prompts helps marketers avoid overreliance on SQL expertise or IT support.

- **Brand center and content blocks:** SAP's Brand Center helps organizations scale content production and apply campaign-level modifications while maintaining brand consistency by separating content structure from visual identity. Reusable Content Blocks can be deployed across email, web and mobile channels, automatically inheriting centrally managed brand themes, design standards and styling variables.

Cautions

- **Suite-centric strategy:** While SAP Engagement Cloud can operate as a stand-alone marketing platform, many advanced data, identity, governance and AI capabilities require additional SAP solutions and licenses. Buyers with non-SAP technology environments may find it challenging to attain ROI at an acceptable total cost of ownership.
- **Implementation timeline:** SAP reports that, while initial deployment can be completed within a few months, full onboarding — including data integration, campaign migration and business value realization — averages nine months. Buyers should evaluate whether the platform's implementation timeline and resource requirements align with their organization's speed-to-value expectations and transformation capacity.
- **Roadmap-dependent autonomy:** While SAP's Joule Assistants are generally available, more autonomous marketing features (e.g., end-to-end campaign generation, real-time optimization) are either on the roadmap for late 2026 and 2027 or delivered through SAP service engagements.

Vendors Added and Dropped

We review and adjust our inclusion criteria for Magic Quadrants as markets change. As a result of these adjustments, the mix of vendors in any Magic Quadrant may change over time. A vendor's appearance in a Magic Quadrant one year and not the next does not necessarily indicate that we have changed our opinion of that vendor. It may be a reflection of a change in the market and, therefore, changed evaluation criteria, or of a change of focus by that vendor.

Added

Two vendors were added to this Magic Quadrant:

- CleverTap
- Klaviyo

Dropped

- Cordial

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

Inclusion Criteria

Magic Quadrants and Critical Capabilities identify and analyze the most relevant providers and their products in a market. The inclusion criteria are the specific attributes that a provider must have to be included in this research.

In addition to Gartner client relevance, as determined by analyst expertise and opinion, providers need to meet the following criteria to qualify for inclusion:

Mandatory Thresholds: General Availability and Market Definition

- **General availability:** The evaluated product or service must be generally available (GA). General availability is defined as a product or service that vendor clients currently have in a production environment, actively sold, and fully supported. Products in beta testing, with limited distribution (e.g., invite-only), or finite duration are not considered generally available.
- **Market definition:** The primary product evaluated must meet the multichannel marketing hubs (MMH) market definition, as outlined in the Market Definition section of this document.

Licensing

The vendor must offer its primary MMH product as a stand-alone or base-configuration (lowest edition tier) license that does not require the purchase of other independent product SKUs. Consumable channel SKUs are excluded from this prohibition.

Financial Performance and Customers

Each provider must meet one of three tiers (all revenue figures must be reported in USD constant currency / FX-neutral):

- **Tier 1.** At least \$500 million in 2025 MMH software revenue, at least 1,500 MMH customers (logos) in 2025, and at least 15 paying net-new MMH customers compared with 2024.
- **Tier 2.** At least \$250 million in 2025 MMH software revenue, at least 250 MMH customers (logos) in 2025, and at least 25 paying net-new MMH customers compared with 2024.
- **Tier 3.** At least \$85 million in 2025 MMH software revenue, at least 150 MMH customers (logos) in 2025, and at least 40 paying net-new MMH customers compared with 2024.

ACV and Revenue Mix

- Average annual contract value (ACV) across all MMH customers must be $\geq$ \$90,000.
- At least 70% of 2025 total company revenue must be attributable to software license sales (SaaS/subscription or new perpetual), MMH or otherwise.

Channel Execution

A vendor must commercialize and execute across a credible portfolio of channels, not merely orchestrate. The 2026 gate has two parts.

- **Portfolio breadth.** The vendor must commercialize at least three of the channel classes as discrete SKUs (see Note 1), and must execute campaigns across all three classes natively or through certified production-grade integrations:
- **Adoption proof.** At least one of the vendor's channel classes must show 50% or greater customer-base adoption, and at least two additional channels must each show 5% or greater customer-base adoption. Adoption is measured as paying customers consuming volume on that channel, not feature availability.

Geographic and Industry Presence

Vendors must have customers in at least two of four global regions and at least 20 current customers across at least three of the specified industries:

- Financial services
- Healthcare/pharmaceuticals

- Retail
- Consumer packaged goods (CPG) and fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG)
- Media and entertainment
- Travel and hospitality
- Technology
- Professional services
- Manufacturing
- Education
- Telecommunications
- Utilities

Exclusion Criteria

A vendor is excluded if its primary commercially available product is a customer data platform (CDP), data management platform (DMP), data warehouse, reverse extract, transform, load (ETL) tool, or identity resolution service, unless the vendor independently commercializes and executes campaigns across three or more channel classes.

Evaluation Criteria

Ability to Execute

We evaluate vendors on the quality and efficacy of the processes, systems, methods or procedures that enable a marketing team's performance to be competitive, efficient and effective, and positively impact revenue, retention and reputation within Gartner's view of the market. With wide-ranging functional, support and service requirements, the following are the important aspects of a vendor's Ability to Execute:

- **Product or service** — We evaluate a vendor's Ability to Execute on the essential and advanced functionalities listed earlier in the Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria section, as well

as evidence of a consistent product release/update cadence indicating the overall health of the vendor's multichannel marketing hub (MMH) solution.

- **Overall viability** — We evaluate the health of the vendor's line of business that offers the MMH solution(s). We also assess the vendor's history of success and development of world-class MMHs and its continued commitment to advancing the state of the art in the company's product portfolio.
- **Sales execution/pricing** — We evaluate a vendor's responsiveness to customer or prospect requests for information, RFI/RFP activities and presales technical support. We also evaluate a vendor's execution during contract negotiation, RFP or quote responses, pricing and negotiation activities, and the overall effectiveness of the direct and indirect sales and sales management organization. We assess the vendor's cost and pricing competitiveness as they relate to competitors with comparable capabilities. This includes the published list price of the vendor's product (licensed or SaaS) and any optional modules needed to meet the minimum product requirements defined above. Also included are annual maintenance fees (if any) and any required services, training, implementation fees, customization or related services.
- **Market responsiveness/record** — We evaluate a vendor's success in creating and meeting a consistent demand for its product, measured in continuing client wins and use among its installed base. We also assess a vendor's strategy for directing resources, skills and offerings to meet the specific needs of geographic regions outside the vendor's "home" region — directly or through partners, channels and subsidiaries as appropriate for that geography and market. Finally, we look for a vendor's demonstrated investment of resources in product development in new areas directly related or adjacent to multichannel marketing in response to market demand or need, along with continued agility in responding to a disruptive business climate.
- **Marketing execution** — We evaluate a vendor's Ability to Execute tactical and strategic marketing campaigns that support a growing customer base, as well as the ability to create and extend its brand as an MMH vendor and visionary in the space. We also look for evidence of a vendor's overall momentum and perceived multichannel marketing focus and presence in the market, as well as continued agility in responding to a business climate characterized by continued disruption.
- **Customer experience** — We evaluate the availability and viability of a vendor's internal customer service and support capabilities, including support resources, systems, policy

and global scope. We also assess the accessibility of a vendor’s external resources. This includes partnerships with global system integrators, consulting organizations and technology partnerships, and related internal or external resources, such as third-party tools or consulting methodologies. Also included are customer-led social networking initiatives, the availability of user groups and SLAs. Finally, we evaluate the perceived ease of use of a vendor’s MMH solution.

- **Operations** — Our measurement of operations focuses on the provider’s ability to meet contracted goals and service-level commitment for its clients. We evaluate the quality of a vendor’s organizational structure, average turnover rate of employees, the breadth and depth of internal resources, as well as any reductions in force or layoffs in the last 18 months. We also assess a provider’s readiness to scale planned strategic initiatives.

Ability to Execute Evaluation Criteria	
Evaluation Criteria	Weighting
Product or Service	High
Overall Viability	Medium
Sales Execution/Pricing	Medium
Market Responsiveness/Record	High
Marketing Execution	Low
Customer Experience	Medium
Operations	Low

Source: Gartner (September 2026)

Completeness of Vision

We evaluate vendors on their ability to convincingly articulate logical statements. This includes current and future market direction, innovation, customer needs and competitive forces, and how well they map to Gartner's view of the market. Vendors that do the following exhibit good Completeness of Vision:

- Demonstrate a clear understanding of marketing organizations' needs.
- Align product development with current and future marketer requirements.
- Set an update cadence that can consistently deliver differentiated functionality against those evolving requirements.
- Support a wide range of use cases.
- Exhibit technological innovation in their products.

Specifically, Gartner assesses a vendor's Completeness of Vision in the MMH market by using the following criteria:

- **Market understanding** — We evaluate a vendor's value proposition in the market, as well as how effective its solution is at reaching the marketing buying center for companies purchasing multichannel marketing solutions. We also assess the vendor's comprehensive vision of external market forces (e.g., consumer trends, the changing regulatory landscape).
- **Marketing strategy** — We evaluate a vendor's effectiveness in accentuating any unique functionality or value proposition, as well as its ability to effectively convey differentiation and vision via market event presence, including webinars and thought leadership programs and overall visibility. We also assess how well a vendor articulates continued multichannel marketing leadership in the context of ongoing business disruption due to global economic conditions and other factors.
- **Sales strategy** — We evaluate a vendor's overall strategy in using direct and indirect sales channels to sell its MMH solution. We also look at a vendor's marketing, customer support and service, or communication affiliates that extend the scope and depth of market reach, skills, expertise, technologies and services of the customer base. Finally, we assess a vendor's depth of demonstrated system integration, technology, application, strategy consulting and distribution partnerships.

- **Offering (product) strategy** — We evaluate a vendor’s approach to the essential and advanced functionalities noted earlier in the Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria section, as well as a vendor’s consistent product release/update cadence indicating the overall health of the MMH solution.
- **Business model** — We evaluate the alignment of a vendor’s go-to-market and sales strategies for particular industries, geographies and delivery models. We also look at a vendor’s product strategy that supports the business model, as well as its product license model (such as SaaS versus a one-time license fee) that effectively supports the targeted market.
- **Vertical/industry strategy** — We evaluate a vendor’s effectiveness in targeting the current market, as well as its ability to direct resources, skills and investment to meet the specific needs of new market segments, users or vertical industry groups. We also assess the degree to which a vendor’s global strategy affects the company’s ability to meet the needs of a global customer base.
- **Innovation** — We look for a vendor’s investment of financial, management, technological or capital resources in the following areas, intended to expand the scope, capabilities or global presence of the company and its products for its customers:
 - Product development in new areas directly related or adjacent to multichannel marketing
 - Sales and support infrastructure
 - Third-party and partner relationships
 - Mergers and acquisitions
- **Geographic strategy** — We assess a vendor’s ability to sell and service multichannel marketing clients in regional markets. We evaluate its regional growth rates as well as its strategy for direct and indirect sales through local service providers. Given the importance of regional consumer privacy and data management regulations, we also evaluate a vendor’s strategies and features for privacy-related innovations.

Completeness of Vision Evaluation Criteria

<i>Evaluation Criteria</i>	<i>Weighting</i>
Market Understanding	High
Marketing Strategy	Low
Sales Strategy	Medium
Offering (Product) Strategy	High
Business Model	Medium
Vertical/Industry Strategy	Low
Innovation	Low
Geographic Strategy	Medium

Source: Gartner (September 2026)

Quadrant Descriptions

Leaders

Leaders provide comprehensive support for all MMH critical capabilities and consistently meet customer needs across core use cases, including implementation, journey building, multichannel optimization and customer journey analysis. In 2026, Leaders increasingly distinguish themselves through convergence: unified suites that bring CRM, customer data, personalization and journey orchestration together in a single operating model, with agentic capabilities demonstrated in production rather than confined to a roadmap. Leaders exhibit high market visibility, strong penetration and sustained momentum, and they pair a well-articulated strategic vision for future MMH growth with evidence of shipped delivery against it. Leaders also succeed in attracting and retaining a diverse customer base across industries and geographies.

Challengers

Challengers execute well against one or more critical MMH use cases — such as journey and campaign orchestration, or workflow innovation — and focus primarily on meeting the needs of established clients. The defining 2026 pattern in this quadrant is delivery outpacing narrative: these vendors ship reliably and serve customers well, but their strategic direction tends to follow market trends rather than set them. Challengers are recognized for the quality of support and partnership they offer, but may lack the breadth of vision or innovation seen in Leaders or Visionaries.

Visionaries

Visionaries excel in emerging MMH functionality — such as AI agents, prescriptive intelligence and two-way conversational engagement — that enables marketers to run leading-edge multichannel programs. They often set strategic direction or introduce innovations that shape future market standards. In 2026, however, a meaningful share of this ambition remains pilot-stage or roadmap-only, so demonstrated capability matters more than announced intent when evaluating vendors in this quadrant. Visionaries show strong potential but may face gaps in execution, service or ecosystem maturity that limit their scale and market impact.

Niche Players

Niche Players address specific needs within the MMH market, often focusing on particular functions, industries or geographies. Their solutions are typically adopted for a subset of use cases — such as mobile-first engagement, email marketing or campaign orchestration — and they may lack a full suite of multichannel capabilities or advanced analytics. In 2026, the addressable niche for single-channel and mobile-first specialists is narrowing as suite vendors absorb adjacent functions, though focused vendors can still hold defensible ground where depth outweighs breadth. Niche Players may also have limited resources or market strategy, resulting in lower visibility and presence compared with other quadrants.

Context

Marketers invest in MMHs to improve outcomes such as revenue, customer engagement, loyalty and lifetime value. MMHs share functional similarities with email platforms, mobile marketing platforms and B2B marketing automation platforms, but are distinguished by their role as the control plane for journey state, sequencing and operational governance across

channels and touchpoints. MMHs are often used together with CDPs, content management tools and the customer's cloud data platform, and they complement adtech and sales, service or commerce CRM solutions. At a minimum, an MMH must enable marketers to use data to deliver personalized content and experiences across addressable channels to known individuals.

MMHs remain foundational and heavily used, yet the gap between platform capability and realized value persists, and in 2026 that gap has changed shape. Every evaluated vendor has released or committed to releasing support for open protocols for agent access, such as the Model Context Protocol (MCP), by the end of 2026. Customers are using that access to build their own recurring, self-directed workflows on top of the platform, often without touching the vendor's interface. Underutilization is no longer only a story of advanced features left untouched; part of a marketing organization's operating capability now sits outside the surface where the vendor placed its controls. With budget scrutiny intensifying and consumption-based pricing spreading, CMOs must reexamine the MMH business case on two axes at once: whether their organization can operate the platform's advanced features efficiently; and whether the vendor's governance model keeps pace with how users actually use it.

Agentic AI remains the market's nominated pathway to transformation. In 2025, agentic journey orchestration was a product strategy rather than a proof point. In 2026, it is crossing into governed production: vendors now ship configurable agents that execute scoped marketing tasks inside policy guardrails, and the most advanced expose customer-modifiable agent specifications with audit trails and named escalation paths. The maturity spread remains wide — much of the market still clusters on assistant-style automation rather than governed autonomy — and the weakest link is control. Few platforms can demonstrate a nontechnical marketer changing what a live agent is allowed to do, with a visible record of the change. As agent-built interactions multiply, our judgment — stated as judgment rather than as something the market has yet demonstrated — is that this control layer, not agent access itself, is where these platforms will separate.

Reflecting these shifts, Gartner's 2026 evaluation brings focus to helping marketers and martech buyers understand and act on capabilities we expect to become essential in the years ahead. Our market definition now treats next-best-action selection and AI agent orchestration as common capabilities, even if they are still in development, rather than differentiators, and we evaluate agentic maturity on a spectrum from rule-based automation through adaptive multiagent workflows. We have raised the evidentiary bar across the board:

capability claims are weighed by their fidelity to real customer operation, with named customers in production carrying the most weight and unsupported assertion carrying the least. And because conversational marketing, mobile marketing platforms and communications platform as a service (CPaaS) are converging into the MMH stack, the evaluation now expects a single identity and consent layer to span owned, conversational, mobile and carrier-grade channels, with composable integration into the customer's cloud data platform as the default rather than the exception.

Readers should weigh Gartner's point of view on the current and future value of MMH solutions and develop their own evaluation criteria for providers' vision and execution. When building business cases for MMH in 2026-2027:

- Establish internally who may change an AI process or agent, what evidence of the change you require and how long the record is kept. Put governance commitments in the contract with dates and remedies rather than leaving them in roadmap conversations.
- Scrutinize consumption and unit-cost telemetry before agentic volume arrives, not after the first overage.
- Test agentic claims in a proof of concept rather than accepting a demo script. Ask the provider to show how a marketer, not an engineer, can change a live agent's instructions, review the resulting audit entry later, and, if necessary, roll back to a prior version.
- Finally, treat adoption as an operating model program, with version-controlled prompt libraries, engineering-like workflow discipline and human approval gates for AI outputs where the action class requires them.

The providers that will serve you best are those that can prove control over what their agents do.

Market Overview

The MMH market has shifted considerably in 2026. Where marketer-focused UX once defined the market, vendors' focus has now shifted to AI access and customer empowerment. Model Context Protocol (MCP) is the defining deliverable of this year's evaluation. By the close of 2026, every evaluated vendor will have released MCP support, and nearly every one of them can demonstrate a conversational surface, a generative content workflow and some form of

agent framework. As a result, vendors' demonstrations increasingly resemble one another, with chatbots dominating their UIs.

If vendor demos all seem alike — a chat with an AI — buyers can find differentiation by changing the focus of the evaluation. The market's most visible investment has been agent-augmented marketing, but even AI agents are no longer a differentiator: every serious platform has them. Differentiation has moved beneath surface-level, AI-assisted messaging to the decision-making layer that determines what any operator — be they human or AI — can actually do in the MMH. Too much activation can easily lead to too many messages, wreaking havoc on customer experience and budgets alike. Without robust decision making — including which message to prioritize for each customer — AI's true impact on MMH could be to undermine the very reason buyers want it: to increase engagement, revenue and brand value.

MMHs Have Expanded Their Remit to Differentiate

Among providers, this transformation of MMH from messaging to decision making most visibly accelerated when Braze acquired OfferFit in June 2025 and folded its reinforcement learning engine into the core engagement layer. Now, most of the vendors in this evaluation offer next-best-action selection, contextual bandits or arbitration natively.

The practical way to assess the decision-making strength of an MMH is to ask how much activation a marketer — or any nonengineer — can see, constrain and override. Platforms differ sharply on what a marketer can do here without filing a ticket to engineering or the data science team. Some providers, but not the majority, let marketers inspect why agents acted, adjust the policies that govern them, streamline their credit consumption, then document changes for review. Even if this need seems futuristic now, MMH buyers should anticipate that this shift toward active decision governance will grow within the term of their contracts, and thus seek out providers that already offer critical capabilities that fulfill them.

MMHs have also extended into channel territory, as rich messaging has shifted from partner integration to native capability. MCP access and a capable external model level the interface, but neither decides which message a customer should receive, on which channel or under which consent state. That judgment sits in the hub. Budget-minded buyers might view large language models (LLMs) commoditizing MMH capabilities as an opportunity to select the least expensive MMH and rely instead on the power or sophistication of an LLM. That trade-off, however, increases the risk of overwhelming should you generate far too much marketing.

Real-time, next-best-action decision making is the hardest layer to implement and scale, and the cost of not having it grows continually. Every time you generate yet another campaign and journey, you'll need even more advanced decision making and control in the MMH.

Marketing Teams Are Moving Beyond the MMH Interface

The most consequential change for the MMH market in 2026 was not a vendor release, but a shift in how users integrate MMHs within *their* workflows. Vendors describe administrators who rarely open the MMH's UI, preferring LLM-mediated experiences instead because they are faster, more rigorous, more agile and iterative.

For example:

- A large airline might assemble its own dashboards.
- An equipment rental company and a membership retail chain could build custom workflows their teams actually use.
- A retailer could build a three-agent system that researches upcoming trends, creates a campaign from segmentation data and reads the performance report to improve the next cycle.

These are production-ready workflows and they run outside the vendors' MMH, either via MCP or through custom-code written through a coding agent. However, in these cases, it's hard to untangle where the value comes from: the MMH or the LLM?

Execution Is a Commodity, Judgment Is Not

MMH vendors must also differentiate their value-add from that of the AI model. Most of the vendors we evaluated let external models both read and write within their platforms, under the same access controls that govern their own native AI. If one capable LLM can drive most platforms through the same protocol, the model starts to look like the differentiator rather than the MMH. Providers will therefore need to do more to justify the value-add above an LLM and a basic multichannel hub.

The rebuttal for MMH is architectural. The decisioning layer is the part worth paying for most in an MMH. In-session decisioning has to resolve inside a few hundred milliseconds, and high-frequency queries against raw warehouse tables are too slow and too expensive to sustain. The strongest decisioning platforms converge on the same design: some essential data

storage, for personalization and orchestration, must reside in the MMH. That resolved local state is exactly what a bare LLM does not have and what campaign management tools do not govern. An assistant can compose a campaign, but it cannot decide what campaigns or journeys to suppress and which returns the highest margin, both within milliseconds and at scale. If the MMH does not provide this decision making, the assistant may decide to act too readily, potentially degrading customer experience with too many offers, messages or triggered interactions.

The strongest performers in this market hold two things in one place: what a customer has been offered and where they sit in a journey. For instance, a hospitality brand might deploy a reinforcement learning agent to manage life cycle communications, making millions of individualized decisions a day to drive transaction lift over a static control group. In a similar vein, a Tier 1 communications provider could leverage a unified event-streaming backbone to consolidate five distinct marketing utilities, reducing campaign setup times from days to under hours. Finally, a high-volume retail scenario might involve replacing a manual discount ladder with an automated agent that selects from four customized incentive levels per customer, driving incremental revenue gains while preserving profit margins.

Three capabilities are key to success for an MMH's ability to scale decision making:

- Marketers should be able to set hard constraints the agent cannot cross.
- The MMH must track AI use, policy compliance and marketing outcomes, so that the platform builds user trust through accountability.
- After proving success, marketers should be able to iteratively expand the agent's domain or autonomy, on their own timeline, without vendor services.

Enforcement Happens at Execution Time or Not at All

As AI-assisted production significantly raises the amount of messaging marketers can make, personalization, suppression and arbitration will become ever more critical.

There is a moment just before a message is sent or an interaction decided in which certain conditions must align: where the customer sits in a journey, what they have already been offered, whether they are eligible for a higher value offer, which channel is open and whether consent still holds. Enforcement of consent is critical at that moment, and without it, marketers face increased risks. For example, if a large multibrand retail group runs a final

consent check immediately before dispatch, across four retail brands sharing one contact store, a suppression recorded at one brand may or may not travel to the others.

Across the market, platforms now check subscriptions at every message node inside a live journey and apply suppression at the point of send.

Fix This in the Contract, Not in the Roadmap

Buyers should consider three diligence questions, each of which a vendor should be able to show in a live demonstration in front of you:

- Ask a marketer, not an engineer, to change a live agent's prompt or guardrail and show the audit entry, so that organizations can roll back any change made by an AI.
- For guardrails, ask where the platform applies the declared constraint, because enforcement at journey entry is not enforcement at each activation step.
- Ask whether a marketer can alter an agent's decisioning without vendor services or forward-deployed engineers.

Treat the answers as commercial terms. A vendor that cannot demonstrate marketer-level agent control today may still be the right choice, but put the commitment in the contract now, with a date and a remedy attached. What a vendor will not put in writing shouldn't be treated as reliable.

Whether a vendor has agents shouldn't drive your selection. Ask instead which vendor can maximize control, cost, reliability and recoverability in response to what those agents may someday do.

⊕ Evidence

Note 1: Classes and Example Channels

Class: Email.

Example channels: HTML email, plain-text email, AMP email.

Definition: Outbound message delivery to a recipient's inbox via SMTP-based protocols, requiring a sender domain and opt-in address.

Class: Carrier-based messaging.

Example channels: SMS, MMS, RCS.

Definition: Messages delivered over mobile carrier networks using standardized telephony protocols, subject to carrier-grade compliance requirements (e.g., 10DLC, CTIA).

Class: Conversational messaging.

Example channels: WhatsApp, LINE, two-way email, agent-augmented chat, Messenger-class consumer apps.

Definition: Session-based, bidirectional messaging conducted within consumer app ecosystems, characterized by reply-capable threads and human-or-agent response handling.

Class: Mobile push and in-app.

Example channels: iOS/Android push notifications, in-app messages, app inbox, live activities.

Definition: Content delivered to a user's mobile device or within a native app, requiring an SDK relationship and device-level opt-in consent.

Class: Web.

Example channels: Landing pages, on-site personalization, web push, pop-ups.

Definition: Owned-surface delivery of content or messages via a browser session, without requiring a carrier or app intermediary.

Class: Walled-garden advertising.

Example channels: Google Ads, Meta Ads (Facebook, Instagram), Amazon Ads, retail media network ads.

Definition: Paid placements within closed platform ecosystems where audience targeting relies on the platform's own identity graph and bidding infrastructure.

Class: Paid media.

Example channels: Programmatic display, retargeting, paid social (non-walled-garden), connected TV.

Definition: Bid-based paid placement across open-web or third-party ad inventory, executed via DSP or ad-network integrations outside a single closed ecosystem.

⊕ Evaluation Criteria Definitions

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